

## **Blind Pianist Says Music Gives Him Energy, Hope**

Takosangba Pongen could see until he was 14 years old. He has been blind for the 13 years since.

But, nobody would know that by watching Pongen perform on the piano.

Pongen said playing the piano helped him after he lost his sight. "It opened a window to see the world. It gives me energy and hope to go forward," he said.

Recently, he performed at the Brillante Piano Festival in Bengaluru, the capital of the southern Indian state of Karnataka.

Pongen plays by ear. He taught himself to play, assisted by piano play training on YouTube that he began using in 2020. He said he would like to be a professional musician someday.

But he is having difficulty finding a place that teaches piano to people with sight, or vision, problems.

Takosangba Pongen, 27, a blind pianist, waits to perform at the two-day Brillante Piano Festival in Bengaluru, India, Sunday, Sept. 29, 2024. (AP Photo/Aijaz Rahi)

Pongen first noticed his vision problems at school. He could not see clearly enough to read words on the blackboard in the room.

Then he remembers having difficulty seeing the small, glass balls called marbles that he liked to play with.

A medical operation to treat the problem failed, worsening his vision. By 14, Pongen was blind.

Pongen says that he sometimes wishes he could see but adds that he also accepts his condition as "God's plan." He believes he is meant to serve as a model in how to face difficulty, lending support to others through example.

"If a blind man can do it, why can't others who are fully able," Pongen said.

Brillante organizers said they believe in the "power of music as an agent of social development." Pongen is a part of their "Specially Abled Musicians" program.

He played Nocturne in B Flat Minor, a work written by Frederic Chopin. Pongen said Chopin is one of his favorite writers of music.

"I love music that is expressive and emotional," he said.

Pongen came more than 3,000 kilometers to Bengaluru. He traveled with his sister, Imlibenla, by his side to play at Brillante Festival, the fifth of its kind. His heart was racing, he said, when the program director, Khyochano TCK, presented him to the other musicians.

Imlibenla Jamir, 30, left, guides her brother Takosangba Pongen, 27, a blind pianist, to the stage for his performance at the two-day Brillante Piano Festival in Bengaluru, India, Sunday, Sept. 29, 2024. (AP Photo/Aijaz Rahi)

The nervousness returned as his performance time arrived. Pongen said he took a deep breath to calm himself.

Then, Imlibenla gently guided him onto the stage. She helped to seat him in front of the piano.

From there, he played beautifully.

I'm John Russell.

Yirmiyan Arthur reported on this story for the Associated Press. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

## Vocabulary

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blackboard - n. กระดานดำ - พื้นผิวที่เรียบแข็งมักจะเป็นสีเข้ม ใช้เป็นพิเศษในห้องเรียนสำหรับเขียนหรือวาดรูปด้วยชอล์ก

## Reading Comprehension Quiz

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**1. According to the article, how old was Takosangba Pongen when he lost his sight completely?**

13 years old

14 years old

27 years old

He was born blind

**2. What is the primary way playing the piano has helped Takosangba Pongen after losing his sight?**

It helped him earn a lot of money.

It allowed him to travel the world.

It provided him with energy, hope, and a new perspective.

It made him forget about his blindness completely.

**3. How did Takosangba Pongen primarily learn to play the piano?**

He attended a music academy from a young age.

He was taught by a private tutor.

He taught himself by ear, with help from YouTube.

His sister taught him everything he knows.

**4. What challenge is Takosangba Pongen currently facing regarding his musical aspirations?**

He is struggling to perform in public.

He cannot afford a piano.

He is having difficulty finding a school that teaches piano to blind individuals.

He doesn't enjoy playing piano anymore.

**5. What was the first sign of vision problems Takosangba Pongen noticed?**

He couldn't recognize people's faces.

He couldn't see clearly enough to read the blackboard at school.

He had trouble playing with small toys.

He felt dizzy and disoriented.

**6. What was the result of the medical operation Pongen underwent to treat his vision problem?**

His vision improved significantly.

His vision remained unchanged.

His vision worsened, leading to complete blindness.

He regained partial sight but still struggled.

**7. How does Pongen view his blindness, despite sometimes wishing he could see?**

He sees it as a curse that limits his life.

He accepts it as 'God's plan' and a chance to inspire others.

He constantly seeks new medical treatments.

He views it as an unfortunate accident with no deeper meaning.

**8. What message does Pongen hope to convey to others through his example?**

That music is the only path to overcoming challenges.

That even without sight, one can achieve anything with enough money.

That if a blind person can succeed, others with full abilities should also be able to.

That people should pity those with disabilities.

**9. What do the Brillante organizers believe about the role of music?**

It is primarily for entertainment purposes.  
It is a powerful tool for social development.  
It is only for people with perfect vision.  
It should only be taught in formal institutions.

**10. Which specific musical piece did Pongen perform at the Brillante Piano Festival?**

A piece by Ludwig van Beethoven.  
Nocturne in B Flat Minor by Frederic Chopin.  
An original composition by Pongen himself.  
A contemporary jazz improvisation.

**11. How far did Pongen travel to participate in the Brillante Festival in Bengaluru?**

More than 300 kilometers  
Less than 1,000 kilometers  
Exactly 3,000 kilometers  
More than 3,000 kilometers

**12. What was Pongen's immediate reaction when the program director introduced him to the other musicians?**

He felt excited and confident.  
He felt calm and collected.  
His heart was racing due to nervousness.  
He was disappointed by the introduction.

**13. What did Pongen do to calm himself just before his performance?**

He meditated for a few minutes.  
He listened to his favorite music.  
He took a deep breath.  
He talked to his sister for reassurance.

**14. Who guided Takosangba Pongen onto the stage and helped him to the piano?**

The festival organizer.  
The program director.  
His sister, Imlibenla.  
A stage assistant.

**15. How was Pongen's actual performance described after he sat down at the piano?**

He struggled with the piece.

He played beautifully.

He had to stop midway.

The audience was unimpressed.